

A GUIDE FOR BUSINESS OWNERS, CEOS, AND ENTREPRENEURS

First Steps to an Effective Sales Process

How to structure your company's pre-sales stage — demand generation, lead qualification, automation, and the role of artificial intelligence — so you stop losing opportunities to a lack of process.



BASE CORE
BUILDING PRODUCTIVE FOUNDATIONS

Sales & Marketing Consulting



INTRODUCTION

The Problem Isn't Effort — It's Process

Your company is growing. Deals are coming in, but each one arrives a different way: one through a referral, another because someone messaged you on LinkedIn, another because a past client sent you a lead.

There's no repeatable path. And as volume grows, that disorder stops being a minor inconvenience and becomes the ceiling on your growth. This doesn't happen because you're not working hard enough. It happens because there's no process.

Having a sales process doesn't mean turning your company into something cold or bureaucratic. It means that every step — from the moment someone discovers you to the moment they buy — has structure, an owner, and clear criteria. This ebook will walk you through the first concrete steps to build that, focusing on the stage where everything gets decided: **pre-sales**.



SECTION 1

Why You Should Segment Your Sales Cycle

Before we get into the details, one idea needs to be clear: **selling isn't a single thing**. It's a journey with clearly different stages, and each one needs its own logic and, when the company can support it, its own owner.

PHASE 1

Pre-Sales

Finding who might be interested in your product and understanding whether there's a genuine need.

PHASE 2

Sales

The negotiation itself: diagnosis, proposal, objections, and close.

PHASE 3

Post-Sale

Making sure the customer gets value from the purchase and comes back to buy again.

When one person —often the owner— tries to do all three at once, opportunities get lost to lack of time and none of the three stages gets done well. Companies with mature sales processes build a small **"role-based funnel"**: someone focused on generating and qualifying opportunities (*pre-sales*), someone focused on closing them (*sales*), and someone focused on sustaining the relationship afterward (*post-sale*). You don't need a large team to get started —sometimes it's the same person working in different time blocks— but you do need that separation of focus. Of these three stages, the one that tends to get the least attention is pre-sales. That's where we'll focus.

Key Concepts, No Fluff

A minimum shared vocabulary — not to sound technical, but because each term marks a different point on the same path.

Database	The contacts and companies that could become your customers. Your starting point.
Audience	Within that database, the segment that actually looks like your ideal customer.
Lead	Someone who's already had a first touchpoint with you and left a detail behind.
Prospect	A lead who also meets the conditions to buy from you (budget, need, authority, timing).
Opportunity	When that prospect shows concrete interest. That's when the sales cycle opens up.



SECTION 2

Pre-Sales: Where It All Begins

The Pillars of Demand Generation Today

Most of your database will never become a sales opportunity —and that's fine. The goal of pre-sales isn't to move everyone forward; it's to quickly identify who's worth pursuing. One of the most common mistakes is relying on a single channel for your entire strategy —typically, a contact form on your website and little else. That's no longer enough.

90%

of B2B buyers start their purchase journey by researching on their own, long before they ever talk to a salesperson. Your presence needs to be built before that first contact.

That's where **content marketing** comes in: creating material that educates or builds trust —articles, case studies, videos, guides— instead of just talking about your product. It's not about being everywhere; it's about picking one or two channels and showing up consistently. Consistency matters more than how many platforms you're on.

Lead Nurturing: Supporting Someone Who Isn't Ready Yet

Not every contact you generate is ready to buy today. **Lead nurturing** means guiding that journey with relevant content instead of writing off anyone who isn't buying yet:

- 1 Define your ideal customer:** who they are, what they need, what holds them back.
- 2 Map their buying journey:** what steps they go through before deciding.
- 3 Segment your database:** not everyone is at the same point in the journey.
- 4 Create content for each segment:** different messages depending on the stage.

When this is done well, sales only steps in once the prospect is actually ready —not too soon, wasting time, and not too late, losing the opportunity.



SECTION 3

Where AI Fits Into Pre-Sales Today

Artificial intelligence is no longer just a side tool for generating text —it's now embedded in the pre-sales process itself. And this isn't a passing trend: it's a structural shift in how a sales opportunity gets generated and qualified. For years, pre-sales was almost entirely limited by human bandwidth —how many messages one person could send, how many leads one person could review in a day. That constraint is starting to disappear, and it's changing the underlying question: it's no longer "how many people do I need to cover this?" but **"what judgment am I giving the machine to make good calls on my behalf?"**

In practice, this shows up in very specific tasks:

- **Automatic qualification:** analyzes whether a contact matches your ideal customer profile —budget, industry, urgency, seniority— within seconds, with no manual screening.
- **Personalization at scale:** nurturing messages tailored to each lead's stage and profile, without writing every one by hand.
- **First-line conversational filtering:** chatbots or dynamic forms that ask the key qualifying questions before a conversation ever reaches a person.
- **Data enrichment:** automatically fills in and updates a contact's information —company, size, what they're investing in— by pulling from public sources, instead of someone looking it up by hand.
- **Purchase-intent prediction:** some systems now analyze behavioral patterns (pages visited, content downloaded, response speed) to estimate how close a lead is to becoming an opportunity, before they say so explicitly.

Here's the key point: AI doesn't replace sales judgment —it frees it up. The teams getting the most out of it aren't sending more messages; they're using data to know when to step in, through which channel, and with what message. AI handles the repetitive work; people still make the decisions that matter: who to talk to first, what to say, and when to get involved.



SECTION 4

Automation as a Foundation, Not a Patch

There's a common misconception: thinking automation just means "using more tools." In reality, automating a sales process means that repeatable tasks —sending a follow-up message, moving a lead from one stage to another, updating a record— happen on their own, based on rules you defined, without anyone having to remember to do them.

This matters for a simple reason: **automation only works well on top of a process that's already organized.** Automating chaos doesn't remove the chaos —it speeds it up. That's why the structure we've covered so far —defined stages, clear roles, criteria for moving forward— isn't an optional step before automation: it's a prerequisite.

Once the process is well defined, automation delivers real, measurable benefits:



Fewer missed opportunities

No lead falls through the cracks because no one remembered to follow up.



Faster response times

First contact can happen in minutes, not days, without depending on someone being available.



Consistency

Every lead gets the same standard of attention, no matter how busy the team is.



Time spent where it counts

People stop losing hours to mechanical tasks and spend it on conversations that require judgment.

Automation, then, isn't the starting point —it's the payoff for having organized the process first.



SECTION 5

The Bridge to Sales

Pre-sales ends when a real sales opportunity appears —not before. Typical signs a prospect is ready to move into sales: they've shown explicit interest, confirmed budget and timing, and there's a decision-maker in the conversation. That handoff needs to be clearly defined —otherwise, mature opportunities get lost to delay, or the sales team wastes time on prospects who weren't actually ready yet.



SECTION 6

The Most Common Mistakes When Building This

- 01 **Making it all about your company:** content that builds trust talks about the customer's problems, not about how great your product is.
- 02 **No clear owner:** without someone owning the content calendar or lead follow-up, it fades out within weeks.
- 03 **Measuring the wrong things:** website visits or followers don't tell you much. What matters is how many leads turned into real opportunities.
- 04 **Expecting instant results:** this kind of process doesn't pay off overnight, but once it's working, it doesn't disappear overnight either.
- 05 **Having no process at all:** ironically, the most common mistake isn't doing any of the above poorly —it's never having defined one to begin with.



SECTION 7

The Bigger Picture: AI and the Sales Process

It's worth looking beyond pre-sales for a moment. Today, a growing share of B2B buyers aren't just researching on their own before talking to a salesperson —some are already delegating part of that research to AI assistants that compare vendors for them, summarize proposals, or even shape the first decision criteria before a human ever joins the conversation. Today's buyer shows up more informed, less tolerant of friction, and looking for clarity more than more information.

AI amplifies what's already working — and exposes what isn't.

This isn't a reason to rush into automating everything. If anything, it's exactly why organizing your sales process matters more now than ever: before adding tools, you need clear judgment. That judgment is exactly what this ebook helped you start building. A company that puts its process in order today doesn't just sell better in the short term —it's positioned to take advantage of every new AI tool that comes along, instead of layering it on top of a foundation that can't support it.

Where Does Your Sales Process Stand Today?

If you've made it this far, you probably recognized some of these points in your own company. The good news: you don't need to fix everything at once —you need to start with the right diagnosis.



WHERE DOES YOUR SALES PROCESS STAND TODAY?

You don't need to fix everything at once. You need to start with the right diagnosis.

If you'd like to go over where your sales process stands today and what steps would make the most sense to take first, book a free audit.

Book my free audit →

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